

Table of Contents

Chapter 1 — Game Design Bible	1
1. Concept	1
2. Design Pillars	1
3. Core Loop	1
4. Player Kit (Locked Numbers)	2
5. Enemy Roster	2
6. Boss: THE BOUND MARTYR	3
7. Combat Feel Principles	4
Chapter 2 — World & Lore Bible	4
1. The City of Ash	4
2. THE DESIGN: One Structure, Two Readings	5
3. Canonical Proper Nouns (Locked)	5
4. The Five Fundamentals of THE DESIGN	6
5. The Four Deliberate Contradictions	6
6. Daily Texture	7
7. What the Slice Must Never Do	8
Chapter 3 — Systems Bible	8
1. OBSERVE Mode	8
2. Entity Schema	8
3. Property Modification Flow	9
4. Consistency (HUNTED Model)	10
5. Belief Mechanics	11
6. Memory Fragments	11
7. Save Schema	11
8. Combat Constants (Locked)	12
9. EventBus: The 21-Signal Spine (Exact)	12
Chapter 4 — Art Bible	13
1. Direction	13
2. Locked Palette	14
3. Post-Process Shader Specification	14

4. Character Sheets (Polygon-Rig Silhouettes)	15
5. Act-by-Act Environment Direction	15
6. Typography	16
7. Forbidden Looks and References	16
Chapter 5 — Narrative & Theology Bible	17
1. The Two Questions	17
2. Reveal Ladder	17
3. The Penitent: Voice Rules	18
4. Canonical Text Inventory	19
5. Ending Specification (Act 9)	19
6. Writing Rules for All Slice Text	20
Chapter 6 — Technical Architecture	20
1. Platform	20
2. Autoloads (5, Locked)	21
3. EntityData Flow	21
4. Room Data Format	22
5. Save Schema	23
6. Signal Spine (Reference)	23
7. Directory Layout	23
8. Audio Bus Architecture	24
9. Corrections and Runtime Validation	24
10. Performance Constraints	24
Chapter 7 — Vertical Slice Specification	25
1. Scope	25
2. Acts, Beat by Beat	25
3. Consistency Budget Ledger	26
4. Enemy Stat Sheets	27
5. Boss Stat Sheet: THE BOUND MARTYR	28
6. Acceptance Criteria	28
7. Content Inventory	29

CHAPTER 1 · PHASE 0

Chapter 1 — Game Design Bible

Phase 0 documentation. Godot 4.4 vertical slice contract. This bible locks the playable feel: pillars, core loop, player kit, enemy roster, boss design, and combat feel principles. Numbers in this file are locked constants; the implementation must match them exactly.

1. Concept

ENTITY_000 is a 2D action/exploration/puzzle psychological mystery set in the City of Ash. The player is ENTITY_000_818: no name, no history, no memory. The first objective printed by the system is RESTORE THE WORLD. The game's central question — the question every mechanic exists to press — is: if you were created for a purpose, do you have the right to reject it?

You awaken in The Cradle, a vertical iron womb beneath the city, and climb toward The Heart of the Design. Along the way you learn to OBSERVE the world's data, to modify the properties that define it, and to pay for every alteration with a resource called Consistency — the measure of how much reality still agrees with you.

The fantasy is not power. The fantasy is jurisdiction: the slow discovery that the world is editable, and the escalating cost of editing it.

2. Design Pillars

Pillar	Statement	What it forbids
Purpose is physics	Every system expresses the world's obsession: purpose, measurement, correction	Decorative lore that has no mechanical echo
Deliberate combat	Attacks are commitments; enemies telegraph; reads beat reflexes	Mashing, combo-cancelling, input strings
Knowledge is a resource	OBSERVE data and Consistency are spent and budgeted like HP	Free information dumps, exposition NPCs
Consequences are rules breaking	Manipulating reality must feel like law violation, never like random noise	Glitch filters with no meaning, random jumpscare
Never explain	The Design is revealed through use, contradiction, and cost	Lore lectures, codex entries that resolve mystery

Pillar five governs all writing. The Design is both a religion and an administrative system; the slice never says which it "really" is, because that ambiguity is the product.

3. Core Loop

The minute-to-minute loop is a decision loop, not a grind loop:

1. **Explore** a room of the City of Ash; read it environmentally (ash, masonry, censored absences).
2. **OBSERVE** anything suspicious: the world slows, a data panel opens, entities expose id, type, state, properties, purpose, memory, belief.
3. **Decide**: accept the world as measured, or modify a property (locked=false, state=TERMINATED, purpose=ABANDON).
4. **Pay**: Consistency is spent only by manipulation, never by combat. The budget is the player's honesty.
5. **Suffer or bank**: lower Consistency escalates staged consequences (stage 4 summons THE CENSOR); ANCHOR shrines checkpoint and save.

The loop's tension is that the two currencies pull against each other: knowledge (OBSERVE, fragments, hidden data) usually costs Consistency, while survival prefers high Consistency. A player who modifies nothing is safe but blind; a player who modifies everything sees everything and is hunted.

4. Player Kit (Locked Numbers)

Ability	Constant	Design intent
Move speed	260 px/s	Deliberate traversal; rooms read at walking pace
Jump velocity	420	Clears 3-tile ledges, not 4; verticality is earned
Max HP	100	~8 meaningful hits early; healing is rare and placed
Attack chain	3 hits, 22 / 22 / 30 damage	Finisher rewards committing to the full string
Roll	380 px/s, 0.35 s, i-frames, 0.6 s cooldown	Panic button with a price; cannot be spammed
Crawl	shape resize, slow move	Access to low passages; vulnerability trade
Coyote time	0.12 s	Forgiveness tuned for 60 fps input
Jump buffer	0.15 s	Forgiveness tuned for 60 fps input
OBSERVE	toggle; time dilation while open	Read the world while it moves slowly around you

Chain rules: the third hit only chains if the second landed within the window; whiffing resets to hit one. Roll grants i-frames for its full 0.35 s duration but its 0.6 s cooldown means it cannot answer two telegraphs in a row — the player must position instead. OBSERVE does not pause the world; it dilates it, so reading a panel mid-combat is a real risk.

5. Enemy Roster

Enemy	HP	Damage	Speed	Role
THE HOLLOW	60	lunge 12	patrol 90 / stalk 150 px/s	Fundamentals teacher
NULL CHILDREN	40	touch 8	drift; no collision	Puzzle-pressure enemy
THE BELIEVERS	80	10	group march	Belief mechanic carrier
THE CENSOR	unkillable	touch 30	120 (stage 4) to 200 (stage 5) px/s	Consistency predator

THE HOLLOW is the absence of identity given appetite. It patrols at 90 px/s, stalks at 150 px/s when it notices you, and telegraphs a 340 px/s lunge with a 0.55 s windup: a visible crouch, a rising audio whine, then commitment. It cannot turn mid-lunge. It is perfectly readable and deeply unsettling, which is the intended teaching pair. At low Consistency it "blinks": a short teleport that breaks spacing taught earlier in the game.

NULL CHILDREN exist outside classification. They drift through walls, deal 8 touch damage, and are invulnerable to the attack chain. Only OBSERVE exposes their state property; setting state=TERMINATED (cost 4 Consistency each) makes them dispersible. They react to Consistency: as stages fall they drift faster and cluster. They teach that some problems cannot be fought, only edited.

THE BELIEVERS are collective belief made flesh. They chant in groups; three or more chanting empower each other by +25% damage each, so a trio hits at 1.75x. Their purpose can be OBSERVE-modified to ABANDON: the ritual stops and they flee. Killing them is free; editing them is not. This is the game's thesis in one enemy.

THE CENSOR is the correction entity and the spine of the HUNTED model. It spawns at stage 4 (Consistency 55–41) and hunts the player through rooms. It cannot be harmed; it corrects. Contact costs 30 HP. Its speed scales from 120 px/s at stage 4 to 200 px/s at stage 5. It is not a failure state — it is the world's objection made physical.

6. Boss: THE BOUND MARTYR

ENTITY_000_001, the first entity, bound in chains at the Reliquary. Its suffering became its purpose. 900 HP across three phases.

Phase	HP range	Kit	Pressure
1	900–600	Chained censor swings, 18 damage	Belief shield held by 2 censor-bearer Believers
2	600–300	FERVOR: arena shrinks (wall of faith), dash attacks 24 damage	Consistency drain aura, 1/s within radius
3	300–0	Chains snap; desperate wide swings, ground slam 30 damage	OBSERVE data evolves mid-fight

Phase 1 teaches the slice's whole grammar in one room: kill the bearers (combat) or OBSERVE-modify the censer's purpose to ABANDON (manipulation) — either drops the shield. Phase 2 turns the arena itself hostile and makes the Consistency economy visible as a combat resource drained by proximity. Phase 3 pays off the evolving OBSERVE readout: the Martyr's purpose visibly rewrites from SERVE THE DESIGN to BE REMEMBERED as it dies.

Death sequence (locked): chains snap, it thanks you, it collapses to ash, and the inscription is revealed: ENTITY_000_001 — FAILED — REPURPOSED. The monument persists into Act 9.

7. Combat Feel Principles

1. **Telegraph everything.** Every hostile damage source is announced by animation, silhouette, or sound at least 0.4 s before it lands. The Hollow's 0.55 s windup is the reference standard.
2. **Commit on both sides.** Player attacks and enemy attacks lock their owners in place. Dodging is a decision to spend the roll's cooldown; attacking is a decision to stand still.
3. **Reward the read, not the reflex.** Damage windows open after telegraphs resolve; the optimal answer to a lunge is a pre-positioned punish, not a reaction parry.
4. **Impact is physical.** Hits land with hitstop, screen shake scaled to damage, and swing trails; the 30-damage finisher must feel three times heavier than a 22 jab through juice alone.
5. **Risk buys knowledge.** OBSERVE stays open in combat at dilated time; reading a panel while a Hollow winds up is the game's signature risk/reward verb.
6. **No crowd-control spam.** Enemy counts stay low (2–5 active) so every encounter is legible; difficulty comes from composition and consistency pressure, not density.
7. **Damage numbers are honest.** 22 means 22. Every HUD value is real state; nothing on screen is cosmetic.

These principles make combat the argument for the game's theme: in a world where everything must justify itself, every button press is a claim of purpose, and the world answers.

CHAPTER 2: PHASE 0

Chapter 2 — World & Lore Bible

Phase 0 documentation. This bible locks the setting's facts, the canonical proper nouns, the four deliberate contradictions the slice plants, and the five fundamentals of THE DESIGN. Canon rule: the slice reveals, never explains. Anything written here as subtext must remain subtext on screen.

1. The City of Ash

The City of Ash is a civilization where a single principle — everything must have a purpose — became a religion, then a law, then a government, and finally reality itself. Nobody in the city experiences this as

history; they experience it as weather. Ash falls eternally, fine and gray, and no one questions it because ash is what remains when purpose has been extracted from things.

The city's population is fading. Not dying — fading: faces lose detail, names stop being remembered, and the census stones need recarving more often. The streets are administratively perfect and increasingly empty. Where people vanish, their purpose sometimes outlives them, drifting loose until something collects it.

The player's route climbs from beneath: The Vessel Chamber (a vertical iron womb), up through The First Door, The City of Ash, The Contradiction, The Chapel of the Pale Saint, The Watching, The Engine Sanctum, and finally The Reliquary. Each district is a stratum of the same idea at a different stage of decay — civic, sacred, industrial, memorial.

2. THE DESIGN: One Structure, Two Readings

THE DESIGN is simultaneously the city's religion and its administrative system. This is the central ambiguity of the game and it is never resolved. The two readings share every outward form:

Form	Religious reading	Administrative reading
THE DESIGN	The divine order of purposes	The master records system
MEASURERS	Priesthood	Clerks and auditors
CENSORED objects	Sin made absent	Deleted records / removed assets
ANCHORS	Shrines where one prays and is kept	Checkpoints where state is written
THE HEART	The god at the center	The engine at the center

The duality is delivered through tone, not twist: a Measurer blesses a doorway with the same gesture they use to stamp a form. ANCHORS both pray and checkpoint — one animation, two true descriptions. The player is never told which reading is correct, and the ending does not arbitrate.

3. Canonical Proper Nouns (Locked)

Noun	Definition	First seen
THE DESIGN	Religion and administrative system; two interpretations of one structure	Act 1, environmental
MEASURERS	Its priesthood and its clerks; the same people	Act 3
THE PALE SAINT	A belief relic: a saint enough people believed in that it became real	Act 5
THE CENSOR	The correction entity that hunts reality-manipulators	Act 7 (spawns at stage 4)
ANCHORS	Save shrines; ritual and system in one object	Act 2

Noun	Definition	First seen
THE HEART OF THE DESIGN	The engine at the center; Act 7 environment	Act 7
THE BOUND MARTYR	ENTITY_000_001, the first entity, bound in chains; mini-boss of Act 8	Act 8
ENTITY_000_818	The player. No name, no history, no memory	Act 1 title / Act 9 reveal
The Penitent	A recurring entity that speaks only in contradictions; never explained	Act 6 sighting

Noun discipline is absolute: these terms are never paraphrased in-fiction. A door is not "sealed by the faith" — it is consecrated under THE DESIGN. Capitalization is canon and appears in OBSERVE readouts, plaques, and dialogue identically.

4. The Five Fundamentals of THE DESIGN

The fundamentals exist as recited text (believers), posted law (plaques), and internal data (OBSERVE). Each has a belief reading and a law reading, exactly as THE DESIGN itself does.

Fundamental	As belief	As law
1. All that exists must serve a purpose	Purpose precedes creation	Existence requires a registered purpose
2. All purpose must be measured	The MEASURERS witness worth	Audits are mandatory and periodic
3. What is purposeless is without reality	The CENSORED were never worthy	Unregistered objects are deleted
4. What is believed by many is measured true	Collective faith creates saints	Consensus data outweighs single records
5. What deviates must be corrected	Correction is mercy, not punishment	Maintenance of the record

A sixth fundamental is whispered to exist. It is never stated in the slice — not on any plaque, not in any readout, not by any NPC. The Penitent's contradictions gesture around its absence. The withheld sixth is the game's most deliberately planted hook for content beyond Phase 0.

5. The Four Deliberate Contradictions

The slice plants exactly four contradictions between the world's accounts of itself. They are the load-bearing evidence that reality here is maintained, not given. Two are mechanically fixable (contradiction fix, 5 Consistency each); two can never be resolved and simply accumulate dread.

Contra diction	Where	Form	Resolution
The plaque against the readout	Act 3–4, DOOR_029 tollgate and the Undercity door	A plaque states the gate has opened for no one since the Third Enumeration; OBSERVE reads the door's memory of openings — the numbers disagree	Fixable: the Undercity contradiction puzzle door opens when the accounts are reconciled (–5)
The room counted twice	Act 4–5, Undercity census stones	Chamber 114 is counted twice in the census; the physical room exists once; at stage 2+ its decor visibly duplicates in sympathy	Never resolvable; escalates visually with Consistency stages
The street that is not	Act 5–6, a Measurer NPC	The NPC remembers Vellum Street with sensory detail — the smell of its bakeries, the pitch of its bells; no such street exists in geometry or record	Never resolvable; at stage 3 the NPC notices you noticing
The records against the mural	Act 6, Archive Loft vs Chantry	The Archive's records enumerate 817 failed entities; the Chantry mural depicts a different number of candle-shrines, and the mural has been corrected by hand	Fixable: the Archive memory contradiction can be reconciled (–5), which is what exposes the hidden platform path at stage 6

Contradiction rules: a contradiction is never flagged by UI. It is discovered by reading plaques against OBSERVE data, or by hearing an NPC insist on something the geometry denies. The game trusts the player to notice; the MEMORY fragment system exists to reward noticing.

6. Daily Texture

Life in the city is bureaucratic liturgy. Toll machines collect purpose-debts at gates; their plaques quote the fundamentals. MEASURERS process queues of the fading, stamping purposes onto people who are losing the definition to hold them. Children are measured early; Null Children drift where classification failed. Nobody is cruel; cruelty would require someone to enjoy this, and enjoyment itself has been measured out of the city long ago.

ANCHORS stand where the city still functions: kneeling markers with a bowl of ash and a thin system-cyan vein of light. Using one is a single gesture that reads as prayer and as a save — the light pulses, the world's state is written, and the phrase ANCHOR ACCEPTED appears in the same typography as every other system message. The first communion at each anchor restores +12 Consistency; below 60 Consistency the restoration is withheld — RESTORATION WITHHELD, RECORD TOO UNSTABLE — mercy has a filing threshold.

The ash itself is the city's quietest confession: the residue of everything CENSORED. It falls eternally because correction is eternal. This is never stated. It is staged: ash thickens near censorship sites, and the Reliquary's ash is deepest of all.

7. What the Slice Must Never Do

- Never explain THE DESIGN's origin, mechanics of divinity, or whether the religious or administrative reading is "true."
- Never state the sixth fundamental, even in endgame files.
- Never resolve The Penitent. It appears, contradicts, and departs.
- Never use the word "glitch" in-fiction. Corruption is experienced as correction: objects are CENSORED, not broken.
- Never confirm the player's origin beyond the numbering: 818 predecessors exist as records; what made them, and what makes you, is withheld.

CHAPTER 3· PHASE 0

Chapter 3 — Systems Bible

Phase 0 documentation. This bible is the systems contract: the full OBSERVE specification, the entity schema with examples, the property modification flow, the complete Consistency model, belief and memory mechanics, the save schema, combat constants, and the exact 21-signal EventBus spine. All numbers here are locked.

1. OBSERVE Mode

OBSERVE is the game's signature verb: a toggle that dilates time and opens the world's data layer.

Behavior. Toggling OBSERVE (dedicated key) slows the world (time dilation; the factor is an implementation tuning value, not a locked constant) and overlays the scene with world-space brackets on observable entities. Cycling targets selects one entity; a data panel renders its record. Closing OBSERVE restores time. OBSERVE never pauses: reading under pressure is intended play.

Readout fields. The panel renders, in order: ID, TYPE, STATE, PROPERTIES (each row: name, value, type; plus MODIFIABLE and COST when applicable), MEMORY, BELIEF, PURPOSE. Property rows gated by `hidden_until` display as SEALED until their condition is satisfied, then resolve into real values — a sealed row becoming legible is itself a narrative event (the Archive records unseal at low Consistency).

Visibility rules. System styling (cold cyan) is reserved for OBSERVE readouts and system messages; no other UI may use it. OBSERVE brackets render in world space so their position teaches entity extents (the Null Child's brackets are slightly wrong — they drift off the sprite, foreshadowing its lack of classification).

2. Entity Schema

All entities are data-driven from `data/entities.json`. The schema is fixed:

id	unique string identifier
type	entity archetype (door, hollow, null_child, believer, censor, boss, npc, anchor, prop, toll_machine, ...)
state	current lifecycle state
properties[]	name, value, type, modifiable, cost, hidden_until
memory	one-line record of what the entity remembers
belief	0-100; strength of collective belief invested in it
purpose	its registered purpose; the field the world enforces
flags[]	gameplay flags (toll_gate, censored, ritual, ...)

Example 1 — a door (Act 3, the first modification):

```
{
  "id": "DOOR_029",
  "type": "door",
  "state": "LOCKED",
  "properties": [
    {"name": "locked", "value": true, "type": "bool",
     "modifiable": true, "cost": 6, "hidden_until": null},
    {"name": "material", "value": "iron", "type": "string",
     "modifiable": false, "cost": 0, "hidden_until": null},
    {"name": "openings", "value": 41, "type": "int",
     "modifiable": false, "cost": 0, "hidden_until": "observe_active"}
  ],
  "memory": "Opened for the toll collector. Opened for the Penitent. Not for you.",
  "belief": 0,
  "purpose": "CONTROL PASSAGE",
  "flags": ["toll_gate"]
}
```

Example 2 — a Null Child (modification as the only weapon):

```
{
  "id": "NULL_CHILD_014",
  "type": "null_child",
  "state": "UNCLASSIFIED",
  "properties": [
    {"name": "state", "value": "UNCLASSIFIED", "type": "enum",
     "modifiable": true, "cost": 4, "hidden_until": "observe_active"},
    {"name": "collision", "value": false, "type": "bool",
     "modifiable": false, "cost": 0, "hidden_until": null}
  ],
  "memory": "A name was being assigned when the process stopped.",
  "belief": 0,
  "purpose": "PENDING",
  "flags": ["drifts_walls", "reacts_to_consistency"]
}
```

3. Property Modification Flow

1. OBSERVE the target and select a property row where modifiable is true.
2. The panel previews the change and its cost in Consistency.
3. Confirm. Gates checked: modifiable, cost affordable, hidden_until satisfied.

4. consistency_spent fires; Consistency decreases by cost.
5. property_modified fires with old and new values.
6. The world responds to the new value: locked=false opens the door; state=TERMINATED makes a Null Child dispersible; purpose=ABANDON ends a Believer ritual.
7. The override is recorded in property_overrides and persists through save/load.

Boss phases route through property_modified on the boss entity — the fight's phase transitions are, diegetically, edits to ENTITY_000_001's record. Purpose rewrites on ritual objects (the Martyr's censor) use the ritual-object cost class: 8 Consistency.

4. Consistency (HUNTED Model)

Consistency starts at 100 and is spent **ONLY** by reality manipulation — never by combat, damage, or death. It is the player's standing with the world's record of itself.

Stages:

Stage	Range	World consequence
S1	86–100	Subtle abnormalities: distant sounds, brief flickers
S2	71–85	Environmental inconsistencies: decor displaced or duplicated, wrong shadows
S3	56–70	NPC awareness: dialogue changes; they notice you noticing
S4	41–55	THE CENSOR spawns and hunts; enemy behavior changes
S5	21–40	Reality actively hunts: corrections spawn near the player, geometry tears
S6	0–20	Hidden structures become accessible

Locked costs:

Manipulation	Cost
Door unlock	6
Toll machine break	8
Null Child termination	4
Contradiction fix	5
Hidden reveal	0 (passive at S6)

Consequence design law. Every staged effect must read as a broken rule, never random noise: a shadow facing the wrong way, a census stone counting a room twice, an NPC mid-sentence noticing you. Stage transitions are announced by a system message in cold cyan — the world filing its objection. Designed budget: a typical player reaches the boss at 60–70; heavy manipulators reach the 30s and unlock S5/S6 hidden content.

5. Belief Mechanics

Belief is the counterforce to Consistency: collective belief makes things real regardless of records.

- **THE PALE SAINT** (Act 5) is a relic that exists purely because enough people believed; its belief field is the highest in the slice. Carrying it lets the player pass the Chantry's ward barrier, which is held by chant, not geometry.
- **Ritual wards** are barriers whose belief is supplied by chanting Believers. Dispersing or ABANDON-ing the chanters drains the ward. Walls of faith cannot be attacked; they must be disbelieved or walked around.
- **The censor shield** (Act 8) is held by 2 censor-bearer Believers; killing them or modifying the censor's purpose to ABANDON drops it.
- **Believers empower each other:** 3+ chanting grant each +25% damage each. belief_changed fires as chant stacks change.

Belief and Consistency are the game's two metaphysics: the record's truth and the crowd's truth. The Design honors both, in that order — until it does not.

6. Memory Fragments

Memory is established through fragments, not through a full memory system (out of scope for the slice). A fragment is earned from: environmental clues (the plaque, the census stone), entity data (OBSERVE memory fields), one meaningful interaction (the Measurer who remembers Vellum Street), and one contradiction (the records against the mural). Collected fragments populate the MEMORY index in the pause menu. Fragment count is a completion vector, never a gate: the golden path requires zero fragments.

7. Save Schema

Saving happens only at ANCHOR shrines (Acts 2, 5, and 8). Each anchor's first communion restores +12 Consistency — but THE DESIGN does not reassure the deeply inconsistent: below 60, restoration is withheld and the anchor only records. One slot, written to user://save.json:

```
{
  "room": "act_03_measured_way",
  "position": {"x": 412, "y": 288},
  "hp": 84,
  "consistency": 68,
  "flags": {"met_masurer": true, "pale_saint_carried": false},
  "fragments": ["frag_plaque_029", "frag_vellum_street"],
  "property_overrides": {"D00R_029": {"locked": false}}
}
```

property_overrides reapplies all modifications on load: the world remembers what you changed. Consistency and its stage are reconstructed from the saved value; the CENSOR's hunt state resumes if stage 4+.

8. Combat Constants (Locked)

Constant	Value
Move speed	260 px/s
Jump velocity	420
Max HP	100
Attack chain damage	22 / 22 / 30
Roll speed / duration / cooldown	380 px/s / 0.35 s / 0.6 s
Coyote time / jump buffer	0.12 s / 0.15 s
Hollow lunge	340 px/s, 0.55 s windup, 12 damage
Believer empowerment	+25% damage per chanter at 3+
Censor speed	120 px/s (S4) to 200 px/s (S5); touch 30
Martyr totals	900 HP; 18 / 24 / 30 damage by phase

9. EventBus: The 21-Signal Spine (Exact)

All cross-system communication routes through the EventBus autoload. No new signals in Phase 0; no direct coupling between gameplay systems.

#	Signal	Payload
1	player_health_changed	hp: int, max_hp: int, source: String
2	player_died	room: String, position: Vector2
3	player_respawned	room: String, position: Vector2, from_anchor: bool
4	consistency_changed	consistency: int, previous: int
5	consistency_stage_changed	stage: int, stage_name: String
6	consistency_spent	amount: int, reason: String, consistency: int
7	correction_spawned	room: String, position: Vector2, target: String
8	entity_registered	entity_id: String, type: String
9	entity_unregistered	entity_id: String
10	observe_toggled	active: bool
11	observe_target_changed	entity_id: String (empty when cleared)
12	property_modified	entity_id: String, property: String, old_value, new_value, cost: int

#	Signal	Payload
13	room_entered	room: String, from: String
14	room_exited	room: String, to: String
15	dialogue_started	dialogue_id: String, speaker: String
16	dialogue_finished	dialogue_id: String
17	flag_set	flag: String, value: Variant
18	fragment_found	fragment_id: String, index: int
19	belief_changed	entity_id: String, belief: int, source: String
20	anchor_used	anchor_id: String, room: String
21	boss_defeated	boss_id: String, final_phase: int

The spine is frozen: no additions, no removals, no renames in Phase 0. Boss phase transitions route through `property_modified` on the boss entity, so no dedicated boss-phase signal exists by design.

CHAPTER 4· PHASE 0

Chapter 4 — Art Bible

Phase 0 documentation. This bible locks the visual law of ENTITY_000: the palette, the post-process grade, character construction as polygon-rig silhouettes, and act-by-act environment direction. The direction is one sentence: gothic religious architecture, industrial decay, digital corruption — in that order of dominance.

1. Direction

Three layers compose every scene:

1. **Gothic religious architecture** — pointed arches, recessed niches, censer chains, shrines. The city believes, and its stonework is liturgy. This layer carries silhouette and composition.
2. **Industrial decay** — iron, rivets, cable runs, toll machinery, pipework sweating rust. The city administers, and its machinery is aging badly. This layer carries texture and narrative wear.
3. **Digital corruption** — cold cyan system veins, OBSERVE brackets, tearing at the frame's edge when Consistency falls. The city is maintained. This layer is the quietest and must never dominate more than 5% of any frame.

Rendering approach: procedural CanvasItem drawing — polygon rigs, masonry renderer, additive glow lighting — over a small set of painterly backdrops graded in-engine by a single post shader. Nothing glossy; every surface absorbs light like ash.

2. Locked Palette

Role	Name	Hex	Usage
Base	Void black	#050506	Deepest shadow, letterboxing, the space between rooms
Base	Charcoal	#141417	Iron structures, background silhouettes
Base	Ash gray	#6f6a5e	Falling ash, distant stone, midground haze
Base	Dirty stone	#3a3733	Load-bearing masonry, floors, walls
Base	Bone white	#d8d2c4	Highest-value surfaces: candles, inscriptions, UI text
Base	Dark brown	#4a3020	Wood, pews, censer handles, dried blood
Base	Desaturated steel	#555a5f	Machinery, chains, toll machines
Accent	Deep blood red	#7a1f1f	Martyr's chains, damage flashes, deepest ritual cloth
Accent	Oxidized crimson	#9a4a3a	Rust, dried offerings, secondary ritual red
Accent	Muted gold	#a8862f	Halo rims, inlay lines, ANCHOR bowls, rare opulence
Accent	Very dark violet	#3a2a4a	Believer robes, Chantry glass, the sacred uncanny
Accent	Cold system cyan	#4fd8e0	OBSERVE readouts and system elements ONLY

Palette law: the seven base tones own 95% of every frame; accents exist in bursts under 5%. Cold system cyan is reserved absolutely — the moment it appears, the frame is making a factual claim. Value structure beats hue: the game must read correctly in grayscale, with bone white reserved for what the eye should find first.

3. Post-Process Shader Specification

A single full-screen pass (post.gdshader) applied via the FX autoload. Uniforms:

Uniform	Type	Range	Driven by
u_grain	float	0.00–0.08	Static film grain; subtle flicker over time
u_vignette	float	0.20–0.60	Composition; deepens during CENSOR proximity
u_tear	float	0.00–1.00	Consistency stage (0 at S1, rising through S2+)
u_tear_time	float	seconds	Horizontal tearing displacement band position
u_observe	float	0.00–1.00	OBSERVE grade blend (1.0 while panel open)

Effects. Grain: animated monochrome noise, heavier in shadows. Vignette: soft elliptical falloff toward void black. Tearing: occasional horizontal displacement bands whose frequency and amplitude scale with `u_tear` — at S5+ bands coincide with `corruption_spawned` events so corruption and consequence stay causally linked. Observe grade: while `u_observe` is high, the image cools and flattens (desaturation plus a

slight cyan lift in midtones), signaling that the player is reading the world's data layer rather than the world.

4. Character Sheets (Polygon-Rig Silhouettes)

All characters are built as articulated polygon rigs — flat dark silhouettes with limited palette accents, animated by code. Readability at a glance is mandatory: each silhouette must be identifiable from its outline alone.

Character	Construction	Palette	Animation signature
Player (ENTITY_000_818)	Lean humanoid, wrapped form, no face — a cowl void	Charcoal body, bone-white edge rim, cyan OBSERVE brackets	Precise: 3-hit chain with visible swing trails; roll is a tucked tumble; crawl flattens the rig
THE HOLLOW	Hunched quadruped-leaning biped, limbs too long, head a smooth blank	Dirty stone body, ash-gray limb joints	Windup crouch held 0.55 s, then a committed flat lunge; blinks collapse and rebuild the rig in two frames
NULL CHILDREN	Small drifting figures, edges unfinished — polygons that do not quite close	Charcoal with hairline cyan seams that flicker	No walk cycle; they drift and rotate slowly; on TERMINATED they unravel into drifting polygons
THE BELIEVERS	Robed kneeling or processing figures, faces hooded, hands clasped	Very dark violet robes, oxidized-crimson sash	Swaying chant loop; chant stacks raise a faint gold shimmer; ABANDON breaks the sway and they scatter
THE CENSOR	Tall administrative silhouette — a clerk's posture, arms too orderly, head a measuring mark	Charcoal suit, bone-white measuring line, cyan edge trace	Walks rather than lunges; corrections appear where it pauses; its restraint is the threat
THE BOUND MARTYR	Massive chained figure, censers as weapons, posture of worship held by iron	Deep blood red chains, oxidized crimson censers, ash-gray body	Phase 1 swings from chains; phase 2 FERVOR tightens the arena wall of faith; phase 3 chains snap and the rig becomes desperate

Contact shadows ground every rig. The player's rig is the most articulated (the only character allowed expressive gesture), because the player is the only entity whose purpose is not yet written.

5. Act-by-Act Environment Direction

Act	Space	Direction
1 · The Cradle	Vertical iron womb	Womb-dark; charcoal ribs, single bone-white light from above; machinery implies birth, not warmth
2 · The Ascent	Service shafts and stairwells	Movement teaching space; generous silhouettes, readable platforms, first ash fall
3 · The Measured Way	Civic thoroughfare	Bureaucratic gothic: queue rails, toll machines, plaques; dirty stone with gold inlay lines

Act	Space	Direction
4 · The Undercity	Beneath the civic layer	Damp masonry, wrong shadows, duplicated decor; census stones; Null Children drift here
5 · The Chantry	Believers' hall of worship	Violet glass, candle banks, the Pale Saint relic niche; the ward barrier as a shimmer of faith
6 · The Archive Loft	Records shelving, iron catwalks	Paper and dust; 817 failure records; the Penitent glimpsed between stacks; hidden platform at S6
7 · The Heart Approach	Industrial cathedral	Nave-scale machinery, cable tracery replacing stained glass; CENSOR pressure; heat and hum
8 · The Reliquary	Boss arena	A shrine turned execution yard; chained Martyr center; ash at its deepest here
9 · Aftermath	The same arena, after	Emptied, quiet, one persistent monument; the grade slowly clears as the question is posed

6. Typography

All UI type is monospaced, technical, and damaged: system messages and OBSERVE readouts render in a terminal face with occasional dropped or duplicated glyphs at low Consistency. Titles may use a serif of funerary weight. Body text never appears in-world outside plaques and records, which are carved (serif, small-caps) rather than printed.

7. Forbidden Looks and References

Forbidden: childish, cute, or chibi proportions; generic neon; glossy or wet surfaces; saturated color outside the accent law; UI chrome that reads as a modern operating system; any iconography that winks at the player.

References are a quality bar only — Blasphemous, Dead Cells, Hollow Knight, Salt and Sanctuary, Darkwood, Signalis, Hyper Light Drifter — for silhouette discipline, animation readability, environmental storytelling, dread pacing, UI restraint, and color law respectively. Copying composition, motifs, or assets from any reference is prohibited; the bar they set is clarity and conviction, not style transfer.

CHAPTER 5 · PHASE 0

Chapter 5 — Narrative & Theology Bible

Phase 0 documentation. This bible locks the narrative law of the slice: the two questions and their placement, the reveal ladder, the voice rules for The Penitent, the canonical text inventory, and the ending specification. The governing rule of all writing on this project: reveal, never explain.

1. The Two Questions

ENTITY_000 is built on exactly two questions, and their placement is law:

Q1 — the central question: If you were created for a purpose, do you have the right to reject it?

Q2 — the secondary question: What happens to a thing nobody believes in?

Placement law:

Rule	Q1 (purpose)	Q2 (belief)
Who asks it	The world asks the player; no NPC ever voices it directly	The world asks it about others, silently
Where it lives mechanically	The player's own record: purpose, flags, the boss's evolving purpose field	Belief values, the Pale Saint, the Martyr, the fading population
First planted	Act 1, the moment RESTORE THE WORLD prints as an order	Act 5, the Pale Saint sequence
Stated verbatim	Exactly once: the final screen of Act 9	Never stated verbatim
Answered	Never	Never — only demonstrated in reverse by the Martyr

The two questions braid: everything that exists in the City of Ash holds its place by purpose or by belief, and the player is the one thing whose existence is argued in both courts at once. The ending's power comes from refusing to close either case.

2. Reveal Ladder

Per act, the slice controls exactly what is shown, what is hinted, and what is withheld. Nothing climbs the ladder out of order.

Act	Shown	Hinted	Withheld
1 · The Cradle	You are ENTITY_000_818; the objective; OBSERVE exists	The world is data under the surface	What 818 means; who numbered you
2 · The Ascent	Movement; the first Hollow; ANCHORS save	The city is emptying	Why the streets are empty

Act	Shown	Hinted	Withheld
3 · The Measured Way	MEASURERS; tolls; the first property modification	The Design is also a records system	The Design's origin
4 · The Undercity	Null Children; contradiction as a mechanic	Rooms miscount; reality is maintained	Who maintains it
5 · The Chantry	Believers; belief makes things real; the Pale Saint	The Saint was only ever believed	The sixth fundamental
6 · The Archive Loft	817 failed entity records; The Penitent	You are not the first; predecessors failed at what, exactly	The Heart's nature; your maker
7 · The Heart Approach	The Heart exists; THE CENSOR hunts manipulators	The Heart maintains the world	Whether the Heart made the Design or the Design made it
8 · The Reliquary	The Martyr's fate; purposes can be rewritten	REPURPOSED has a specific meaning	What happens to 818
9 · Aftermath	817 predecessors failed; you are 818; the restored world may not include you	That restoration and inclusion may be separate line items	Everything else

Ladder law: a withheld item may be advanced to hinted by environmental staging, but only the acts listed may promote it to shown. The word "soul" never appears in the slice.

3. The Penitent: Voice Rules

The Penitent is the slice's one recurring unexplained entity. Rules are absolute:

1. It appears at least twice (a full sighting in Act 6; at least one earlier peripheral appearance).
2. It speaks only in contradictions — every line must be formally self-opposing.
3. It is never explained, never named in-fiction by NPCs, and never enters combat.
4. It never lies. Its contradictions are the most literally true statements in the game.
5. Its typography differs from all other dialogue: slightly corrupted glyphs, no speaker label.

Canonical Penitent lines (locked; the full set is three to five lines across the slice):

- "I have always been sorry. I was never here."
- "You will remember me incorrectly. That is how I remain."
- "The street I mourn was never built. I walk it every day."
- "Do not believe me. I am the only thing they all agreed on."

The Penitent's final line, if the player has collected the memory contradictions, is delivered at the Archive Loft and concerns the sixth fundamental by refusing to state it: "There is a sixth. It is the one they never wrote down. That is how you will know it is the true one."

4. Canonical Text Inventory

All in-fiction text belongs to one of five classes. Wording below is canonical; plaques render in carved serif small-caps, system messages in the terminal face.

Plaques (civic, posted law):

- Tollgate plaque, Act 3: "THIS GATE HAS OPENED FOR NO ONE SINCE THE THIRD ENUMERATION." (The OBSERVE readout disagrees: 41 openings. The first planted contradiction.)
- Census stone, Act 4: "CHAMBER 114. CHAMBER 114." (One room, counted twice. Never resolvable.)
- Fundamentals posts: the five fundamentals, verbatim from the World & Lore Bible, one per post.

Ritual text (Chantry, recited):

- Believer chant: "Measured, measured, measured be. What is measured cannot leave."
- Ward consecration: "Hold what is held. Believe what is believed."

Inscriptions (memorial):

- The Martyr's revealed inscription, Act 8, exact: "ENTITY_000_001 — FAILED — REPURPOSED"
- The monument, Act 9, carries the same inscription, unchanged, persistent.

System messages (cold cyan, terminal face):

- "OBJECTIVE: RESTORE THE WORLD" (Act 1; the opening order)
- "CONSISTENCY: {value}" and "CORRECTION IN PROGRESS" (stage transitions and CENSOR events)
- "ANCHOR ACCEPTED" (save)
- "PROPERTY MODIFIED: {entity}.{property}" (every manipulation; the world files its objection)

OBSERVE data text: memory fields carry one-line records written as testimony ("Opened for the toll collector. Opened for the Penitent. Not for you."). Memory fields are the only prose the world addresses to the player directly.

5. Ending Specification (Act 9)

Act 9 takes place in the Reliquary after the Martyr's death, with the monument persistent and the arena emptied of threat. The sequence is locked:

1. The player approaches the monument; the inscription is legible and unchanged.
2. The system reveals, in its own typography and pacing, the count: 817 predecessors, failed; you are ENTITY_000_818.
3. One system line states the stake: the world you restore may not include you.
4. The game then prints the central question, verbatim, and stops:

If you were created for a purpose, do you have the right to reject it?

1. No answer options. No epilogue cards. The question holds on screen until the player exits; the title returns with the question ghosted into its background.

Ending law: the ending is a question, not a lore dump. Nothing in Act 9 may resolve the Design's duality, the Penitent, the sixth fundamental, or the player's origin. The only new information is the count and the stake — everything else the player already earned on the ladder. The final emotional target is not triumph or grief but jurisdiction: the question of whether refusal is a right the player can claim, left deliberately in the player's hands.

6. Writing Rules for All Slice Text

- Contradictions are never flagged; they are stated plainly by two authorities that disagree.
- NPCs speak in administrative liturgy; warmth leaks through procedure, never around it.
- The Design is never explained by any character who would know; those characters are unavailable, fading, or bound.
- Damage, death, and correction are described in record language, never in violence language.
- Every proper noun is used exactly as locked in the World & Lore Bible, capitalization included.

CHAPTER 6· PHASE 0

Chapter 6 — Technical Architecture

Phase 0 documentation. This bible is the engineering contract: platform constraints, the five autoloads and their responsibilities, the EntityData pipeline, room data format, save schema, the signal spine, directory layout, and performance budgets.

1. Platform

Item	Value
Engine	Godot 4.4+
Language	GDScript
Renderer	gl_compatibility
Resolution	1280 x 720, fixed
Scene strategy	Code-first scene construction; a single <code>main.tscn</code>
Data strategy	Data-driven entities (<code>data/entities.json</code>); rooms as data
Target	60 fps on integrated graphics at 1280 x 720

Code-first means the room graph, entities, UI, and effects are constructed in GDScript at runtime rather than authored as many scene files. Authoring stays in two places: JSON data and the single entry scene. This keeps the 9-act slice auditable — a room is a record, not a file hierarchy.

2. Autoloads (5, Locked)

Autoload	Responsibilities
EventBus	Owens the 21-signal spine; the only channel for cross-system communication
GameState	Consistency value and HUNTED stage machine; corrections; flags; save/load; input map
EntityDB	Loads <code>data/entities.json</code> ; templates; instantiates and holds the live entity registry
AudioManager	Music states, ambient layers, SFX pool, chant channel; consistency-driven bus lowpass and pitch degradation
FX	Screen shake, hitstop, and the post-process CanvasLayer (grain, vignette, tearing, observe grade)

No gameplay system may reach into another system directly; all coupling routes through EventBus signals. GameState is the single authority on Consistency — nothing else may decrement it — and the only writer of `user://save.json`.

Autoload order is fixed and load-bearing: EventBus first (it must exist before anything emits), then EntityDB (data before world), then GameState, AudioManager, and FX. Ownership is equally strict: the bus routes but never decides; the database stores but never simulates; game state arbitrates but never draws; audio and FX present but never mutate gameplay values. Any feature that cannot be located inside exactly one of these five homes does not belong in the slice.

3. EntityData Flow

The pipeline from data to world response is fixed and one-directional:

```

data/entities.json
|
v
EntityDB (load + templates)
|
v
instantiate on room build --> entity_registered
|
v
live registry (room-local, typed EntityData)
|
v
OBSERVE panel (readout; target cycling)
|
v
modification (gates: modifiable, cost, hidden_until)
|
v
consistency_spent -> property_modified
|
v
world response (door opens; state=TERMINATED; purpose=ABANDON)
|
v
property_overrides recorded -> save/load reapplies

```

EntityData is a typed runtime record: id, type, state, properties (each with name, value, type, modifiable, cost, hidden_until), memory, belief, purpose, flags. hidden_until conditions are evaluated statically against GameState (for example, a records shelf that unseals at Consistency stage 3+). Boss phase transitions are property_modified events on the boss entity — the Reliquary fight is, mechanically, the player watching ENTITY_000_001's record being rewritten.

4. Room Data Format

Rooms are data. A room record declares geometry, contents, and transitions:

```

{
  "id": "act_03_measured_way",
  "display": "THE MEASURED WAY",
  "bounds": {"w": 3840, "h": 720},
  "floors": [{"x": 0, "y": 640, "w": 3840}],
  "platforms": [{"x": 900, "y": 480, "w": 160}],
  "walls": [{"x": 0, "y": 0, "w": 32, "h": 720}],
  "spawns": {"player": {"x": 120, "y": 600}},
  "entities": ["DOOR_029", "TOLL_003", "MEASURER_01", "HOLLOW_02"],
  "anchors": [{"id": "ANCHOR_A3", "x": 1840, "y": 640}],
  "triggers": [{"id": "trg_first_hollow", "x": 700, "w": 80, "once": true}],
  "exits": [{"x": 3808, "to": "act_04_undercity", "spawn": "left"}],
  "ambient": "amb_undercity",
  "music": "mus_measured",
  "backdrop": "bd_measured_way"
}

```

The room builder constructs collision, spawns entities from EntityDB templates, wires triggers and exits, and requests audio from AudioManager. Transitions emit room_exited then room_entered; the registry is

rebuilt per room so OBSERVE cycling only ever sees current-room entities.

5. Save Schema

Single slot, written at ANCHOR use only:

```
{
  "room": "act_05_chantry",
  "position": {"x": 640, "y": 512},
  "hp": 71,
  "consistency": 49,
  "flags": {"ward_passed": true},
  "fragments": ["frag_plaque_029"],
  "property_overrides": {"D00R_029": {"locked": false}}
}
```

Load path: read JSON, rebuild room, re-apply property_overrides through EntityDB, recompute Consistency stage, restore fragments and flags, emit player_respawned. Death without an ANCHOR restores the last save; death is never a Consistency event.

6. Signal Spine (Reference)

The exact 21-signal spine with payloads is locked in the Systems Bible (03, section 9): player_health_changed, player_died, player_respawned, consistency_changed, consistency_stage_changed, consistency_spent, correction_spawned, entity_registered, entity_unregistered, observe_toggled, observe_target_changed, property_modified, room_entered, room_exited, dialogue_started, dialogue_finished, flag_set, fragment_found, belief_changed, anchor_used, boss_defeated. Architecture rules: no signal additions in Phase 0; every payload is a plain dictionary; EventBus performs no logic — it routes.

7. Directory Layout

```
entity000/  
  project.godot  
  main.tscn  
  data/  
    entities.json      entity definitions (schema in 03)  
    rooms.json         9 act rooms as data  
  scripts/  
    autoloads/  
      event_bus.gd, game_state.gd, entity_db.gd,  
      audio_manager.gd, fx.gd  
    player/  
    entities/  
    world/  
    ui/  
    post/  
      post.gdshader  
  art/  
    painterly backdrops (graded in-engine)  
  audio/  
    music/ ambient/ sfx/ procedural WAV library  
    MANIFEST.md        authoritative file list, durations, usage  
  docs/  
    the seven bibles + Phase 0 PDF
```

The audio library is 48 procedural WAVs (10 music, 5 ambient, 33 SFX) authored to the audio identity: ancient, sacred, mechanical, lonely, damaged. `audio/MANIFEST.md` is the authoritative per-file list; code must reference paths exactly as the manifest records them.

8. Audio Bus Architecture

AudioManager exposes music states (title, exploration per act stratum, combat, boss phases), ambient layers (wind, machinery, chant beds), a pooled SFX voice allocator, and a dedicated chant channel for Believer groups. Consistency drives degradation across the master bus: as stages fall, a lowpass filter closes and playback pitch drifts downward, so the mix itself decays with the world's record of the player. Bus graph: Master, Music, Ambient, SFX, Chant.

9. Corrections and Runtime Validation

The correction system is owned by GameState: at stage 4+ it may spawn correction events near the player (`correction_spawned`), each a small localized reality edit — a duplicated decor piece resolving, a seam tearing in geometry — rendered by FX as a tear band. Corrections are never lethal by themselves; their job is to keep the HUNTED model legible: the world is visibly spending effort on you.

Validation strategy for development: headless Godot runs boot each room from the room data and assert that the registry builds, entities resolve against EntityDB templates, and every exit references an existing room. Scripted input simulations drive the golden path, a combat exchange, and the boss fight through phase 3. Screenshots rendered under a virtual display are reviewed against the Art Bible palette law. Any assert failure, parse error, or unresolved audio path fails the build; the slice ships only from a clean validation pass.

10. Performance Constraints

Budget	Constraint
Frame	16.6 ms; gl_compatibility; no per-frame allocations in gameplay loops
Post pass	One full-screen shader; uniform updates only on state change
Entities	2–5 active enemies; pooled projectiles and particles
Audio	Preloaded WAVs; zero runtime synthesis; pooled voices with early cull
Rooms	Single room resident; transition tears down the previous registry
Draw	Batched CanvasItem polygons; backdrops are single textured layers with parallax, not tile fields
Save	Anchor-only writes; JSON under 16 KB

Validation gates for the slice: zero parse errors on editor import; every room boots standalone; the golden path completes under scripted input; screenshots of all nine acts verified against the Art Bible. Acceptance criteria for the full slice live in the Vertical Slice Specification (07).

CHAPTER 7· PHASE 0

Chapter 7 — Vertical Slice Specification

Phase 0 documentation. This bible is the acceptance contract for the 9-act vertical slice: beat-by-beat act structure, the Consistency budget ledger, enemy and boss stat sheets, acceptance criteria, and the content inventory. Everything numeric here is locked and matches the Systems Bible.

1. Scope

The slice delivers the golden path from awakening to the ending question: 9 acts, 15–30 minutes for a first-time player, with optional manipulation extending skilled or exhaustive runs. All five mechanic pillars must be functional and demonstrable in a single run: OBSERVE, property modification, Consistency (HUNTED model), belief, and memory fragments.

2. Acts, Beat by Beat

Act	Room	Beats	Systems taught
1	The Vessel Chamber	Awakening in the iron womb; the system prints OBJECTIVE: RESTORE THE WORLD; climb toward the single light; exit up the shaft	Movement; no combat; no OBSERVE yet — sight is not issued
2	The First Door	A dead TERMINAL_019 installs OBSERVE; the DOOR_029 tollgate blocks passage; its plaque states it has opened for no one; the record says 14,207	OBSERVE; first property modification: locked=false, -6; the first ANCHOR; S1 begins

Act	Room	Beats	Systems taught
3	The City of Ash	Procession street with faceless statues; first dialogue with MEASURER OREN stamping the fading; the first HOLLOW patrols	Dialogue; telegraphed combat; the plaque-vs-readout contradiction is planted
4	The Contradiction	Null Children drift through walls; DOOR_114 requires reconciling plaque and readout (fix, -5); census stones count Chamber 114 twice; an optional toll gate (break the machine, -8, or roll beneath it)	Null Children; contradiction as mechanic; optional spending begins
5	The Chapel of the Pale Saint	Believers chant a ward into existence; the Pale Saint relic; the candle rail; the ward admits the relic bearer or one who has joined the ritual — or collapses when the chant stops (ABANDON, -8)	Belief mechanics; three real solutions; carrying belief
6	The Watching	The Archive: 817 failed records; the Penitent appears between stacks; the discrepancy ledger (fix, -5); a record station where you may read yourself; a hidden platform for stage 6 players	Fragments; the Penitent; reading your own record; hidden content gating
7	The Engine Sanctum	An industrial cathedral of cable-tracery and heat; THE HEART OF THE DESIGN works; three rotors must be aligned in the sequence hidden in their OBSERVE memory; CENSOR pressure applies to stage 4+ players	The alignment puzzle via OBSERVE; escalation; environment-as-boss
8	The Reliquary	THE BOUND MARTYR fight, three phases; the belief shield held by two censor bearers (kill them or rewrite the censor's purpose to ABANDON, -8); death sequence: chains snap, it thanks you, it collapses to ash, the inscription is revealed	All systems converge on one entity's record
9	Aftermath	The monument persists; the count is revealed (817 predecessors failed; you are ENTITY_000_818); the restored world may not include you; the game prints the question and stops	The ending; no new mechanics

Pacing targets: Acts 1–3 about 8 minutes, Acts 4–6 about 12, Acts 7–9 about 8; a rushed golden path completes in about 15, a first exploratory run in 25–30.

3. Consistency Budget Ledger

Costs are locked (door unlock 6; toll machine break 8; Null Child termination 4; contradiction fix 5; hidden reveal 0 at stage 6). The ledger is the cumulative floor if the player manipulates everything available:

Act	Manipulation	Cost	Cumulative spent	Consistency after	Stage
3	DOOR_029 locked=false (golden path)	6	6	94	S1
4	Contradiction door fix (golden path)	5	11	89	S1
4	Null Child terminations, Undercity clusters (x8)	32	43	57	S3
4	Toll machine break, Undercity checkpoint	8	51	49	S4
5	Toll machine break, Chantry collection gate	8	59	41	S4

Act	Manipulation	Cost	Cumulative spent	Consistency after	Stage
5	Side-chapel door unlock, Chantry	6	65	35	S5
6	Archive stacks door unlock	6	71	29	S5
6	Archive record contradiction fix	5	76	24	S5
6	Archive annex door unlock	6	82	18	S6
6	Hidden platform reveal (passive)	0	82	18	S6
7	Maintenance gate unlock	6	88	12	S6
7	Null Child terminations, approach drift (x2)	8	96	4	S6

Stages are evaluated after every individual spend, so sequential terminations pass through every intermediate stage and its staged consequences. Player archetypes against the ledger:

Player	Behavior	At boss (start of Act 8)
Minimal	Golden path manipulations only (11 spent)	89, S1
Typical	Golden path plus a few optional edits (30–40 spent)	60–70, S3
Heavy	Most optional edits (60–70 spent)	30s, S5, actively hunted
Exhaustive	Everything available (96 spent)	4, S6; hidden platform seen in Act 6

Boss Phase 2's FERVOR drain aura (1 Consistency per second within radius) applies after this table and can push any archetype one stage lower during the fight; it is the only combat-adjacent Consistency loss in the game, justified diegetically as the Martyr's own reality manipulation.

4. Enemy Stat Sheets

Enemy	HP	Dam age	Speeds	Special
THE HOLLOW	60	lunge 12	patrol 90, stalk 150, lunge 340 px/s	0.55 s telegraph; blink teleport at low Consistency
NULL CHILDREN	40	touch 8	drift; no collision	Invulnerable until OBSERVE state=TERMINATED (4); reacts to Consistency
THE BELIEVERS	80	10	group march	3+ chanting: +25% damage each; purpose=ABANDON ends ritual
THE CENSOR	unkill able	touch 30	120 px/s at S4, 200 px/s at S5	Spawns at stage 4; cannot be harmed; corrects

5. Boss Stat Sheet: THE BOUND MARTYR

ENTITY_000_001. 900 HP. Arena: the Reliquary. Phase transitions at 600 and 300 HP, routed through `property_modified` on the boss entity.

Phase	HP range	Attacks	Arena state	OBSERVE data
1	900–600	Chained censer swings, 18 damage	Belief shield held by 2 censer-bearer Believers; kill them or modify the censer purpose to ABANDON (8)	purpose: SERVE THE DESIGN
2	600–300	Dash attacks, 24 damage	FERVOR: arena shrinks as a wall of faith; consistency drain aura, 1/s within radius	purpose: SERVE THE DESIGN
3	300–0	Desperate wide swings; ground slam, 30 damage	Chains snap; full arena	purpose rewrites to BE REMEMBERED

Death sequence (locked): chains snap, the Martyr thanks you, it collapses to ash, and the inscription is revealed: ENTITY_000_001 — FAILED — REPURPOSED. The monument persists into Act 9.

6. Acceptance Criteria

Done means all of the following pass:

1. **Playable end to end:** a first-time player finishes Acts 1–9 in 15–30 minutes on the golden path; no soft-locks anywhere, including the Archive Loft after optional edits.
2. **Every UI value is real:** HP, Consistency, stage, damage numbers, OBSERVE readouts, and MEMORY index render live state; nothing on screen is decorative.
3. **Golden path verified by script:** walk, dialogue, first OBSERVE, DOOR_029 locked=false (Consistency 94), door opens, room transition, contradiction fix, boss kill, death sequence, ending question — all under simulated input.
4. **All nine rooms boot standalone** with zero parse or runtime errors on editor import.
5. **The five pillars are demonstrable in one run:** OBSERVE, modification with costs, staged Consistency consequences, belief (ward and shield), and at least one fragment.
6. **Boss integrity:** three phases with correct thresholds and damage values; shield drops by either method; the purpose field visibly evolves in phase 3.
7. **Save/load round trip** at an ANCHOR restores room, position, HP, Consistency, flags, fragments, and property overrides exactly.
8. **Audio correctness:** every played file resolves to a path listed in `audio/MANIFEST.md`; consistency-driven lowpass and pitch degradation audibly track stages.
9. **Art law:** screenshots of all nine acts pass review against the Art Bible; system cyan appears only in system elements.

10. **Performance:** 60 fps at 1280 x 720 on integrated graphics through the heaviest room (Act 7).

7. Content Inventory

Category	Count	Notes
Rooms	9	Data-driven; one per act
Entity definitions	40+	<code>data/entities.json</code> ; schema per Systems Bible
Enemy types	4	Hollow, Null Children, Believers, Censor
Boss	1	The Bound Martyr, 3 phases, scripted death
EventBus signals	21	Locked spine, payloads per Systems Bible
Audio files	48	10 music, 5 ambient, 33 SFX; manifest authoritative
Backdrops	8	Painterly, graded in-engine
Post shader	1	Grain, vignette, tearing, observe grade
Character rigs	6	Player, Hollow, Null Child, Believer, Censor, Martyr
Save slots	1	ANCHOR-only writes
Fragments	8–12	MEMORY index; zero required on golden path
Deliberate contradictions	4	Two fixable, two permanent
Documentation	8	Seven bibles plus this compiled PDF

Out of scope: a full memory system, multiple endings, difficulty modes, localization, and resolution of any withheld lore item listed in the Narrative & Theology Bible.